CASE STUDY

Shaheen Ansari, 35, Lucknow

Teastall owner

Monthly income: Rs 14,000-16,000

Education: BA in Sociology and Political Science; diplomas in Desktop Publishing and Cosmetology

A Different Cup of Tea

Shaheen was just five when her labourer father died. She paid for her education by tutoring young children. In 2011, she graduated with a degree in Sociology and Political Science from Shashi Bhushan Degree College, Lucknow, after which she earned a diploma in Desktop Publishing. As Shaheen started looking for jobs, she realised the long working hours and low salary hardly seemed worth it—the job of a computer operator offered Rs 7,000 monthly and a call centre job too paid only Rs 6,000 for an eight-hour workday. She quit both after working for a few days. She then decided to pursue a diploma in Cosmetology in 2016, but jobs at salons were no different. "I was offered Rs 5,000 per month without a single weekly day off," says Shaheen. In May 2022, she decided to open a tea stall opposite Tulsi Theatre in Hazratganj. "I have an interest in cooking, and I have turned that into my business," she says. 'Lucknow Chaiwali' operates from 7 am to 10 pm and has built a regular clientele. "Now, I am my own boss and I also earn more than I did in the private sector."

—Ashish Misra



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



"The talent pipeline has not kept pace with the rapid modernisation of shop floors. Many applicants come in with theoretical certification but need 3-6 months of on-the-job training before they're truly productive"

RAHUL GAMA, *CHRO, CEAT*

The NITI Aayog report highlights the multiple disconnects across the education, skills and jobs axes. Candidate aspirations often differ from job realities; curricula are outdated and misaligned with industry needs; the education system runs on a parallel track to skilling; and talent is not always available where the jobs are.

MISMATCH 1

SKILLING SHORTCOMINGS

The Industrial Training Institutes, or ITIs, have long been the backbone of India's skilling system. Providing courses that can last from six months to two years, or even for a few weeks for those seeking upskilling in new technology, these vocational training courses aim to equip students with industry-relevant skills after Class 10 or 12 and provide formal certification for otherwise manual and technical trades like electricians, welders, machinists, car mechanics and air-conditioning technicians, bringing dignity to them. Fees for government ITIs is highly subsidised, starting from Rs 1,000 a year; private ITIs are much more expensive: their fees can vary from Rs 10,000 to Rs 50,000 a year, depending on the course.

Currently, India has 14,789 ITIs, with 2,538,487 seats. However, capacity utilisation stands at just 48.2 per cent, meaning roughly one in every two seats is vacant, according to NITI Aayog's 2023 report, 'Transforming Industrial